

# AI Is A New FOREST FIRE

Yes, AI is spreading like a forest fire through the job market. Tens of thousands of engineers across India lost their jobs to AI-driven restructuring last year and continue to do so this year. It is not about the economy, policy, or the numbers. It is about you, the one affected by it right now, wondering what the way forward is.



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If you are a recent graduate, you might be worried about getting a job. If you already have one, you might be worried about losing it. This is especially true in the technology industry, particularly in software and other fields where AI can now do much of the work. I know it is hard. Many people in similar situations may be looking for a magic pill, something that fixes everything immediately. But there is no such thing. There was no magic pill that earned you your education, none that helped you secure the job you have or once had, and similarly, there is no magic pill to fix the present situation.

However, halfway through this article, we will explore some new paths within employment. This is not a substitute for career advice, legal guidance, or your own independent judgement. It is meant to encourage you and stand by you during these difficult times, perhaps from a different perspective than you have considered before.

## It did not select you for a reason

When a tsunami strikes, the earth shakes, or a forest fire spreads, it does

not stop to check who deserves it. It does not ask who worked harder, whose family is in trouble, or who was more deserving of being spared. It takes whatever is in its path. That is exactly what is happening across tech corridors in India and beyond (Fig. 1).

AI-driven restructuring is like a forest fire. It is not a judgement on you.

If you lost your job, it was not because of your inability. It was not because you were useless. It was the result of a major shift, and a major shift does not check merit lists before it arrives.

## AI was already cooking before you were born!

Of course, AI's effects are new, but AI itself is not. The effort and pursuit began long ago, before many of us were even born (Fig. 2). That means we were born when AI was already cooking in the kitchen. Everyone had heard of it, some could even smell it, and a few even helped build it. But only a handful understood what would happen once it was ready to be served. That is why most people were caught unprepared. Perhaps this is nature's own way of teaching us to stay vigilant.